scandal. We ended a run of ten consecutive wins and enabled South Africa to become the first side to be ranked number one in all three formats. I told Alice about my promotion, but otherwise kept the following day's headlines to myself.

Straussy sent us all a personalized letter and we bought him a hundred bottles of wine in return. I love the bloke. He embodies everything you wish for in a leader: calmness, fairness, fierce pride and consistent purpose. He's the rock-solid guy everyone looks up to, whether you are walking out to bat with him or asking for quiet guidance.

My abiding loyalty towards him couldn't be fairly factored into my first decision as captain: whether we could, or should, bring back KP. I didn't go out of my way to talk to Straussy about it, first, because I couldn't be distracted and, second, because I didn't want to be influenced emotionally by the respect I had for him. I was trying to do what I thought was best for the team, not best for me or my mate.

While I privately weighed up the pros and cons, I had my public initiation as England captain in the arena I liked least: the press conference. The question I hated most arrived on cue: 'What leadership style can we expect from you?' Put simply, it is hard to answer when you don't truly know. You get picked for the job because people see leadership qualities in you, but it's hard to put into words, beyond an appreciation of the honour and the intention to do what comes naturally.

I eventually relaxed into the role after about eighteen months, but was worried about how I came across as a public speaker. I panicked initially, when I had to articulate ideas or strategies in front of the squad. I was uncomfortably aware of Swanny giggling in the corner because I'd misquoted a saying or put my words in the wrong order in a jumble of thoughts.

Media training is useful, to a degree, but sport involves operating on instinct. I knew what I wouldn't do following a leadership seminar in the City of London at which a prominent chief executive stood up and said: 'I tell my employees to reach for the stars. They might not get the stars, but they get the moon. That's a bloody long way.'

If I had come out with that tosh, I'd have been laughed out of the dressing room. The truth is that nothing can prepare you for the England captaincy. Experience of doing the job in county cricket might offer tactical experience and acumen, but it has limited relevance because of the